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PHILOSOPHY OF HISTORY

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Introductory Remarks

The basic concepts: 'Philosophy' and 'History' are both distinct branches of knowledge but are as well complimentary. Furthermore, within the ambient of philosophical studies, we have 'History of Philosophy' and 'Philosophy of History'. Despite the similarities, the contents of both are not the same. 'History of Philosophy' is a study which focuses on the origin and development of philosophical thought. In this case, the object of study is 'philosophy' while the method of study is 'historical'. On the other hand, in 'Philosophy of History', the object of study is 'history' while the method of study is 'philosophical'.

Philosophy

Etymologically, the term philosophy comes from the ancient Greek words φίλος (philos) which means 'love' and σοφία (sophia) which means 'wisdom'. Hence it literally means 'love of wisdom'. As a branch of knowledge, Philosophy refers to the methodical inquiry into reality as a whole. It is a way of thinking. Philosophy generally refers to the study of deep, fundamental questions relating to core aspects of human existence and experience. These questions typically revolve around the nature of existence, knowledge, consciousness, ethics, society, language and so on. It is a critical and logical investigation that considers its assumptions and techniques.

In other words, Philosophy is the methodical and intellectual investigation of issues that are difficult to resolve with merely empirical observation. Philosophers investigate the nature of reality, human behaviour and the cosmos, using logic, reason, and critical thinking.

History

The Greek word 'historia' means an enquiry. History so to say is an enquiry about things said, thought and done in the past following their evidence in the present through research. As an academic discipline, history involves the methodical study of the past. It analyses and interprets evidence to create narratives about what happened and why. Human beings have always been

interested in understanding and interpreting their past. As such, history is a pursuit common to all human societies and cultures.

Every reality has an interconnectivity with time and space. There is always a 'was' that gives rise to an 'is'. Simply put, our present is the product of a past, of history. In other words, history probes into, reconstructs and interprets what happened in the distant past and in the immediate or contemporary past. All the events that gave rise to the present are objects and materials of history. The history of a person will involve his birth, parents, schools attended, work experience, health challenges, travels and every other detail connected to this person. The same applies to non-human realities: cultures, nations, institutions, languages, science, knowledge/discipline and so on.

I. PHILOSOPHY OF HISTORY

Having given a brief explanation of the key concepts, an attempt will be made to explain the meaning or nature of Philosophy of History. One can simply say that this study involves a philosophical study of history in all its aspects¹. In other words, it refers to a rational inquiry into the field of history. It studies the meaning, trends, and fundamental ideas of human history. It aims to comprehend the cause, intent, and character of historical occurrences, frequently delving into the question of whether history has any clear direction or significance.

This discipline is credited to the works of Voltaire who developed the term in his work *La Philosophie de l'histoire* of 1765. Voltaire was a French writer, historian and philosopher. He was very skeptical about the traditional way of studying and relaying history on the basis that such narratives have the tendency to incorporate exaggerations, superstitions and myths that lack basic methodology of verification. Hence, Voltaire sought to develop fresh new ways of studying history that will focus on verifiable facts and incorporate rational and analytic methods of study².

This study makes use of the methods found in the fundamental branches of philosophy, such as metaphysics, epistemology, and ethics, to inquire about the nature of the past and how we know it. Such questions include: does the past happen randomly or according to a principle of order; how best can we explain or characterize historical events and objects in a scientific manner; how do we evaluate historical testimony and evidence in order to sieve out verifiable facts?

¹ Humphrey U. Ani, *Introduction to Philosophy of History*, (Enugu: SNAAP Press, 2021), p. 80.

² Guillaume de Syon, "Voltaire" in K. Boyd (ed.), *Encyclopedia of Historians and Historical Writing*, vol 2. (Taylor & Francis, 1999), pp. 1270–72.

II. HISTORIOGRAPHY

The major contribution of philosophy to the domain of history is the insistence of authentic methodology and synthesis in the writing or discussion of history. This rational approach to history gave birth to Historiography.

Historiography refers to the application of the principles of academic discipline to the study and writing of history. For a study to be seen as a discipline, there should be a methodology that entertains a critical and analytic study. In other words, historiography is the writing of history based on the critical examination of sources so as to achieve authenticity. When these sources are verified, then the important details are sieved from these verified sources and synthesised into historical narratives that can stand a verifiable test. Simply put, it is the writing of history by making use of certifiable techniques of research.

Naturally, before the art of writing, humans passed information about the past to the next generation by the use of stories. The veracity of such stories was authenticated only by their continued repetition. When humans invented literary writing, such narratives were also put in print. However, with historiography, the veracity of historical accounts was no longer from repetition but by verification of facts.

In a loose sense, historiography refers to any historical work that deals with a particular subject matter. It describes the body of history written about a particular person, period or event. For instance, the historiography of the Nigerian Civil War describes every significant book written about that war.

Historiography as a discipline is recent. It was developed in the 18th century. Before the 18th century, History was just seen as any other human activity but not considered as part of regular education or object of academic study. Academic disciplines then were poetry, religion, philosophy and so on. It was only during the Age of Enlightenment that scholars like Voltaire, Hume, developed Historiography and thus gave History an academic form. By the 19th century, historical studies became professionalized at universities and considered as an academic discipline³.

In the words of Voltaire, “One demands of modern historians more details, better ascertained facts, precise dates, more attention to customs, laws, commerce, finance, agriculture, population”⁴. Voltaire’s aim is to depart from the theological and regal assumptions and focus on verifiable facts of history. He held that former historical accounts were falsified with superstitions and traditional tales to enhance the kings, emperors, nobles and ecclesiastical authorities. To the contrary, he demanded that modern history has to be based on objectivity and anchored on verifiable and precise facts. Departing from the traditional way of recounting histories according to religious and

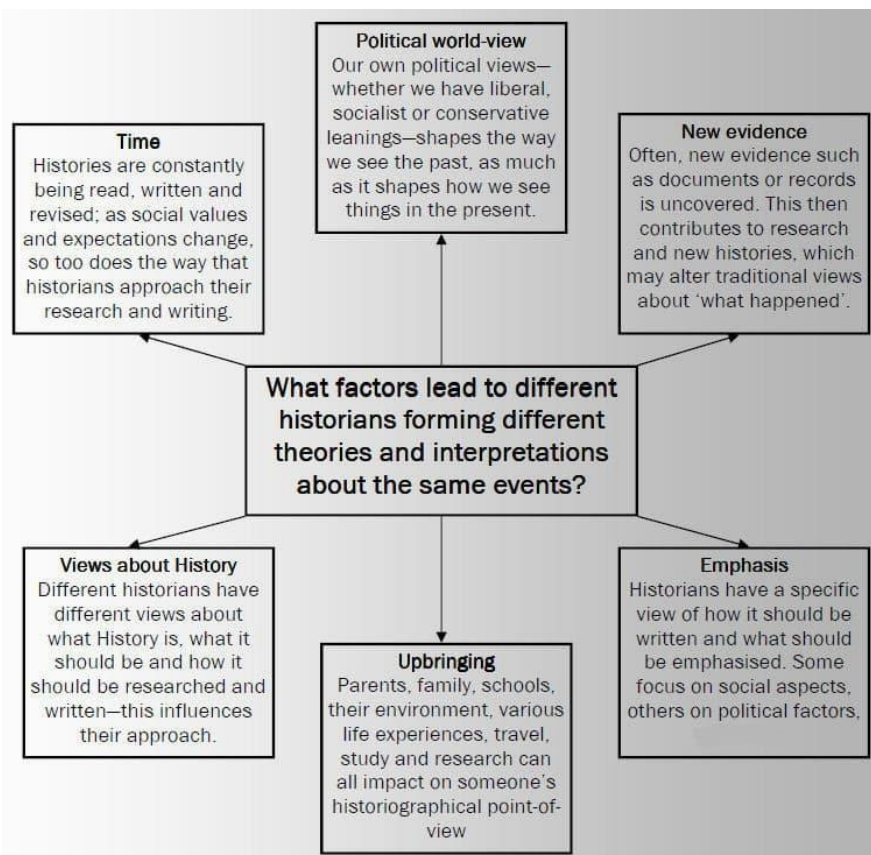
³ Georg G. IGGER, *Historiography in the Twentieth Century: From Scientific Objectivity to the Postmodern Challenge*.

⁴ E. Sreedharan (2004). *A Textbook of Historiography: 500 BC to AD 2000*, (India: Orient Blackswan, 2004) p. 115

imperial accomplishments, he focused rather on social history, accomplishments in the arts and sciences, economics, culture, and political history. He was the first scholar who made attempt to articulate the history of the world.

Historiographical Concerns

As historiography focuses on the method of writing history, it is concerned with not just the study of how history is written but also how our perception of it evolves or changes over time. In order to understand how and why historians' beliefs and interpretations differ, historiography takes into account the methods they employ.



From the above chart, it is clear that a lot of factors come into play in the evaluation and interpretation of the past. The way the past is interpreted can vary but yet the past itself never changes. Based on their individual approaches, values, and interests, contemporary historians investigate and analyse the past. They produce fresh hypotheses and findings that could alter our perception of the past. This process of transformation is recognized and studied in historiography.

Important facts to note about Historiography:

There are some basic things to note in the study of historiography.

First, we must acknowledge that history is never final. Even if the past never changes, our perceptions of it are constantly subject to debate, critique, and revision.

Secondly, historiography makes us understand that there is a difference between history and historical facts. History is the study and interpretation of historical events while historical facts refer to details that have been verified or proven true by evidence. Referring to historical facts, the role of the historian is to make sense of these facts through research and analysis. Historiography prompts the historian to examine and interpret evidence, form conclusions and articulate their findings in writing.

III. HISTORICISM

Consider these two approaches to the meaning of the word ‘seminary’:

1. A seminary is an institution where candidates intending for the Catholic priesthood are trained.
2. Seminary was part of the Church’s counter-reformation approach, established in the sixteenth century in order to produce priests well vested in knowledge and disciple, able to dispel and surmount the attacks of Luther and the protestant reformers.

The two definitions above look similar but are also different. Although they differ, both are accurate, it is just a matter of approach. The first defined the seminary based on the function it fulfils in the present society. The other defined the seminary based on its historical foundations. The first approach is known as *functionalism* while the second is known as *Historicism*.

Historicism is a method that studies the history of a phenomenon in order to understand it. It is a method in the evaluation of truth which has as its basis, the assumption that all knowledge and cognition are historically conditioned. In its nature, it puts to question certain traditionally held beliefs. Thinkers tend to maintain that human rationality is a universal mental faculty capable of understanding unchanging and universal reality. However, historicism puts a challenge on this belief, arguing that the historical context of each phenomenon determines its essence.

Historicism as a method is adopted in diverse disciplines especially philosophy, history, anthropology and sociology. It is a tool employed for understanding the origins of social and cultural phenomena and is frequently used to contextualize theories and narratives.

Historicism as a term was coined in the 18th century by the German philosopher Karl Wilhelm Friedrich Schegel⁵. He invented this concept in his bid to develop a philosophical system that emphasises the importance of history in shaping human ideas and actions⁶. In other words, it believes that the meaning and value of things is found in their history. According to Lee and Beck, historicism makes a claim that historical knowledge is a basic, or the only requirement for understanding and educating man's present political, social and intellectual positions or problems⁷. It takes cognizance of the diversity and uniqueness of phenomena in human existence.

Friedrich Hegel

One of the main proponents of historicism as an integral part of philosophy of history was Hegel. For Hegel, there is a necessity inherent in history in the evolution or understanding of reality. History becomes then an essential requirement in any quest to understand reality. In other words, to grasp the meaning of any reality, one must necessarily try to understand its origin and development in time.

In philosophical enquiry therefore, Hegel proposes history as the indispensable tool for comprehension. For Beiser, history is very central to Hegel's conception of philosophy⁸. Hegel proposes history as the soul and substance of profound truth of man and reality at large. Having developed the spirit (Geist) as the supernatural force that directs all human actions and interactions, Hegel posited that 'History in general is the development of spirit in time, as nature is the development of idea in space'⁹.

In his *Introduction to Lectures on the Philosophy of World History* (1837), Hegel postulated that history is classified into three different types. First is the 'original history' which refers to first-hand accounts of events and situations that were verified and witnessed by the historian himself. Original history, which Hegel termed a mental representation of reality, allows us to better comprehend a people's culture, traditions, values, and way of life: we get an insight into the spirit of a particular era. In this view, oral tradition (oral sources in African History), are especially

⁵ Brian Leiter, Michael Rosen (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Continental Philosophy*, (Oxford University Press, 2007), p. 175

⁶ Lieter and Rosen, *The Oxford Handbook*, *ibid*.

⁷ William Lawhead, *The Voyage of Discovery-A Historical Introduction to Philosophy*, 4th ed., (Boston: Cengage Advantage Series, 2015), 385.

⁸ Frederick Beiser, "Hegel's Historicism", in Frederick Beiser (ed.), *The Cambridge Companion to Hegel*, (Cambridge University Press, 1993).

⁹ Georg Friedrich Hegel, *The Philosophy of History*, trans. J. Sibree (New York: Prometheus Books, 1991), 90.

essential because they capture a specific moment and location¹⁰ (Abdullahi et al, 2021). Original history gives us a sense of what happened at a particular time, it translates physical events into the realm of representative intellect¹¹.

Hegel then talks about reflective history which, unlike original history, does not deal with the specific period of the historian but analyses in the present, histories or historical events that have already occurred, for instance, the history of Igbo people. This type of history focuses on providing an overview of historical events that have already happened.

The third form of history according to Hegel is philosophical history. It is more of a thought driven form of history unlike the original and reflective histories which are event driven. According to Hegel, philosophical history tries to synthesize historical data with philosophical conceptions and ideas, placing emphasis on thought over events. For Hegel, this form of history is most important because the course of human history is constantly directed by the principle of reason.

IV. HOLISM AND INDIVIDUALISM IN HISTORY

Historicism talks of the necessity of historical context in the search for meaning or nature of any phenomenon. This gives rise to the question of how these historical contexts should be understood or analysed. How do we understand history? Should history be understood in a wholistic manner or based on particular data? Is a historical narrative understood without reference to a universal body where it belongs, or should it be understood only in the context of its relationship to a wider body where it belongs? For instance, can the biography of a priest be written without reference to the general concept of the meaning and purpose of the Catholic priesthood?

This enquiry brings to light the concepts of holism and individualism in philosophy of history.

Holism

Holism as a concept is derived from the Greek term ‘holos’ which means ‘all’. ‘whole’, ‘entire’. It simply refers to the believe that the ‘system as a whole determines in an important way, how the parts behave’. The term was coined by Jan Christian Smuts (1870-1950), a philosopher and former Prime Minister of South Africa¹². In 1926, Smuts published a work *Holism and Evolution* where he developed his view on creative evolution¹³.

¹⁰ Stephen BELCHER, *Oral Traditions as Sources*, Online Pub., <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190277734.013.363>, accessed 30 May, 2024.

¹¹ Robert BROWN; Peter HODGSON (eds.), *Hegel: Lectures on the Philosophy of World History, Volume I: Manuscripts of the Introduction and the Lectures Of 1822-1823*, (Oxford University Press, 2019).

¹² H. Ani, *Introduction to Philosophy of History*, 135.

¹³ Jan Christian Smuts, *Holism and Evolution* (London: Macmillan Inc. 1926).

The idea of a universal principle that governs phenomena is as old as philosophy. Heraclitus talked of *Logos* and *Pantheism*. Parmenides thought of the *Nous* as the universal principle that governs reality and is thus greater than every part which derives from it.

Holism as a concept in philosophy of history is a philosophical theory that asserts that individual history or individual experiences of history can only have meaning from the wider perspective of universal history or world history. Proponents of this theory like Hegel and Marx insist that universal history or the principles of history determine in a necessary way, the knowledge and meaning of individual history. For instance, the theory of the absolute spirit in Hegel or material economy in Marx plays a major role in the comprehension of particular histories of specific societies. In other words, the whole essentially gives meaning to its parts.

The proponents of this theory assert that it is the world history that gives meaning to particular history. The history of a particular society like Nigeria can only have meaning within the context of the universal principles that governs the history of nations. Our personal historical experiences have meaning only when considered within the wider context of general history. In other words, all parts of the society are intimately interconnected through history and no single part can exist independently of the whole.

Critics of holism point to the fact that it proposes a deterministic origin of reality, hence human existence too is a natural necessity. In other words, holism questions or negates the role of freedom in the making of history: an event of the past is a product of necessity and not freewill.

Individualism

Unlike holism, individualism insists on the uniqueness of each history. It proposes that the individual is sovereign to the society. It places emphasis on the specificity and significance of a particular part of a whole as the key and center of meaning. In other words, particulars have intrinsic meanings independent of universals. In this case, history finds its meaning in the individual or particular histories of a people or society without reference to universal principles.

Individualism as a social theory was developed by the French philosopher Alexis de Tocqueville (1805-1859). He described individualism from the perspective of social interaction where he asserts that individualism is a moderate selfishness that disposes humans to be concerned only with their own circle of friends and family¹⁴.

It should be noted that individualism is different from individuality. The concept of individuality implies the uniqueness of each individual or personality. On the other hand, individualism talks of the significance of particular histories in the shaping of meaning. As a social theory, individualism encourages individuality, diversity and freedom over authority and conformity.

¹⁴ H. Ani, *Introduction to Philosophy of History*, 141.

In the history of philosophy, some thinkers have ascribed to the sovereignty of particulars over universals. The Socratic dictum 'Man know thyself' exhibits elements of individualism. Augustine went ahead to define a person as 'every single man' while Boethius defined man as 'an individual substance of a rational nature'. Hence, value and meaning lies in singularity independent of the whole.

In the philosophy of history, individualism asserts that the individual or the parts of a whole possess the essential sources of understanding. Therefore, world history is nothing but an evaluation of individual histories or histories of independent states. The histories of particular people like Nigeria have inherent significance irrespective of other histories of other states. Therefore, priority rests on the history of maybe ethnic groups or races. These singular histories provide the means and principles of understanding world histories.

Critics of individualism insists that such notions promote moral relativism, discourages the purpose of authority and enthrones selfish tendencies.

V. DIRECTIONALITY IN HISTORY

History is the study of past events. An event occurred in the past is the object of history. Some thinkers tried to understand the nature of occurrences in history especially as it relates to the final cause or goal of history. The question then is to determine if there is an order or pattern in the sequence of events. This is known as the directionality of history. Directionality in history is all about time: what is the connectivity between past, present, and future?

The study of history has long struggled with a central question: is the evolution of civilizations linear, characterized by a constant path toward advancement and higher stages of development (like climbing a staircase), or cyclical, characterized by recurring patterns of rise and fall? Fundamentally, the linear viewpoint proposes a forward-moving trajectory that frequently leads to an ultimate goal, whereas the cyclical view contends that history is driven by recurrent patterns. Among the thinkers who focused on this, the most prominent are Ibn Khaldun, Hegel, and Toynbee.

Cyclic Direction

Proponents of the cyclic direction understood history to be repeatable in nature. History follows the pattern of recurring moments in time. The events of history are realised in a cyclic pattern provided that the factors that cause these events are constant and repetitious. For instance, the seasons of the year are the same every year – from dry season to rainy season which in turns is

followed by another dry season and so on. Also, day is followed by night and night ushers in another day. Hence, historical pattern involves the repetition of same events in time.

Ancient societies subscribed majorly to the cyclic notion of history. Ancient historians like Herodotus believed that history repeats its events in a cyclic order.

Applying this to human society, thinkers like Ibn Khaldun said that human societies are characterized by the rise and fall of civilizations caused by social cohesion, economic factors and moral dynamics. When a particular civilisation collapses, a new one rises seizing the opportunity of the weakened state or the former declining civilisation. This new group starts its phases of growth, maturity and subsequent decline, to give way to another new group. All is movement in cycles.

In cyclic history, determinism holds sway, human efforts have little to contribute, events occur repeatedly at given times. In spiritual discussions, it also ascribes to the belief in reincarnation.

Linear Direction

In historical context, the term "linear" refers to the idea that history progresses in a straight line, moving forward from one point to another. This perspective suggests that events and societies evolve in a progressive manner, with each stage building upon the previous one, moving towards an ultimate goal.

The linear direction of history can be said to be the trademark of the Jews. Judaism broke from ancient concept of cyclic history to a linear direction in history. This is deduced from "The Creation" account in the Scriptures (Book of Genesis). Creation was done in time, in different phases and done sequentially, day by day. There is no cycle here; there is no re-creation. The time is linear here. The linear history is dominant in Judaism and Christianity. St. Augustine and some Patristic fathers ascribed to the linear pattern of history. For Augustine, history does not repeat itself and the aim or finality of history is beyond earthly considerations.

Applying this to human societies, Hegel believed that history evolves through a series of interconnected stages driven by the reconciliation of conflicting elements. As civilisations grapple with and resolve conflicts within their social and philosophical frameworks, they move towards novel systems of structure and knowledge. Each period in history has its conflicts and obstacles that serve as steps toward achieving freedom and self-awareness. For example, ancient despotic governments symbolised freedom as power resided with the ruler, while contemporary constitutional states emphasise liberty to all members of society¹⁵. It involves a continuous progression of different phases: from past to the present and to the future. Each phase in this progression plays a role in humanity's quest towards achieving freedom and self-awareness.

¹⁵ Kamal, M. (2022). Hegel's logic. Mang publishing.

VI. PHILOSOPHERS OF HISTORY

Aristotle (384-322BCE): In the History of Philosophy, one of the earliest mentions of History as a discipline was in Aristotle's philosophical treatise on aesthetics known as the Poetics. In this work, Aristotle focused on the nature of literature and analysis of the literary method. In one of the sections, he tried to attest to the philosophical superiority of poetry over history. According to him, poetry focuses on what might happen or could be thought to happen, but history deals with events that happened in the past.

The problem of historical narratives is that it deals with specifics whose relationships are characterized by chance or accident, whereas poetic narratives deal with determined objects and logically connected by a storyline through necessity. Poetry is more philosophical than history since it came close to revealing universal truths. In other words, poetry deals with what ought or must be true while history deals merely with what is true¹⁶.

Plutarch (46-120CE): He was a Platonist philosopher. He dedicated a good part of his work reflecting on History especially as regarding its meaning and purpose. Plutarch insisted that the purpose of history was to provide generations with good examples. This influenced his approach to history. For him, historical narratives should focus on those historical subjects whose actions and contributions can morally improve the reader.

This idea of history as a moral enhancer influenced historical writers from the ancient times and through the medieval period. Historical writings then focused on Church saints, great emperors and kings.

Ibn Khaldun (1332-1406): Towards the end of the medieval period, Islamic scholars took a center stage in philosophical thought and social sciences. One of such was Ibn Khaldun who was a renowned socialist and a historian. The contribution of Khaldun to history gave rise to the scientific method of historical enquiry known today as historiography¹⁷. Khaldun was preoccupied with the unquestionable authority of history in the medieval period. As was mentioned, historical narratives formerly focused only on great personages and events aimed at offering good values to the society.

¹⁶ Silvia CARLI, "Poetry is more philosophical than History: Aristotle on Mimêsis and Form", In *The Review of Metaphysics* 64, no. 2 (2010): 303–36. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/29765376>.

¹⁷ George SARTON, *Introduction to the History of Science. Science and Learning in the Fourteenth Century*. Vol. 3. (Baltimore: The Williams & Wilkins Company, 1948) p. 1262

However, the problem with such is that it can also be embellished with exaggerations, myths and superstitions. This was the concern of Khaldun, how actual truth can be sieved from historical narratives to avoid what he called the “uncritical acceptance of historical truth”. Ibn Khaldun is reputed to have written some historical works especially History of the Arabs.

Voltaire (1694-1778): Originally known as François-Marie Arouet but used Voltaire in his writings. He was a French scholar, philosopher and historian. Voltaire was a prominent figure of the Enlightenment Movement of thought in Europe. Known for his critical approach to issues, he was known for questioning a lot of institutional assumptions especially regarding religion and politics. Voltaire’s ideas influenced the French and American revolutions.

He is known as the father of Philosophy of History. In his *Essai sur les Moeurs et L'Esprit des Nations*, he named the first chapter as ‘Philosophy of History’. For Voltaire, this concept "Philosophy of History" stood for two things. First, it insists on an examination of certain facts recorded and of the views entertained in traditional historical books concerning the past life of humanity. This was where Voltaire promoted his idea of freedom of speech and criticized traditional institutions like the church or what he termed the outrageous control that the church possessed over people. In the second place, “Philosophy of history” for Voltaire was an attempt to reinterpret the religious, moral, and aesthetic beliefs, as well as the traditions and behaviours that were prevalent in earlier societies. By this way, Voltaire aimed at shedding "a glaring light upon the intellectual climate of the eighteenth century".

For instance, Voltaire questioned some historical assumptions of his time, like whether Zeus and other Greek gods were just invented names or were they real ancient human heroes; or whether the skin colour of Africans was due to the extraordinary imaginative power of the women of these two races, making them reproduce in their offspring the colours with which their husbands paint themselves?¹⁸

Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770-1831)

Hegel was a German philosopher of absolute idealism who developed a dialectic conception of history. Hegel’s contribution to the Philosophy of History is mainly contained in his lectures and theses on the *Philosophy of World History* developed during his time at the University of Berlin.

Hegel’s philosophy is rooted in history. For him, philosophy is only possible "if it is historical: only if the philosopher is aware of the origins, context, and development of his doctrines"¹⁹.

¹⁸ Kim Marquard, Voltaire’s Philosophy and Its Impact, https://www.academia.edu/23712786/Voltaire_s_Philosophy_and_Its_Impact, (accessed 2nd January 2025).

¹⁹ Frederick BEISER, "Hegel's Historicism", In F. Beiser (ed.). *The Cambridge Companion to Hegel*, (Cambridge University Press, 1993).

Hegel's Philosophy of History sought to provide a philosophical analysis of world history by considering human history in all of its temporal and spatial dimensions. Specifically, Hegel wanted to ascertain the teleology of history, or the end, goal or purpose of history and how this end will be realized²⁰. On this note, Hegel applied his metaphysical and logical philosophical system to develop the thesis that the history of humanity consists of a rational process of constant progress towards freedom²¹.

In his *Introduction to Lectures on the Philosophy of World History* (1837), Hegel postulated that history is classified into three different types. First is the 'original history' which refers to first-hand accounts of events and situations that were verified and witnessed by the historian himself. Original history, which Hegel termed a mental representation of reality, allows us to better comprehend a people's culture, traditions, values, and way of life: we get an insight into the spirit of a particular era. In this view, oral tradition (oral sources in African History), are especially essential because they capture a specific moment and location²² (Abdullahi et al, 2021). Original history gives us a sense of what happened at a particular time, it translates physical events into the realm of representative intellect²³.

Hegel then talks about reflective history which, unlike original history, does not deal with the specific period of the historian but analyses in the present, histories or historical events that have already occurred, for instance, the history of Igbo people. This type of history focuses on providing an overview of historical events that have already happened.

The third form of history according to Hegel is philosophical history. It is more of a thought driven form of history unlike the original and reflective histories which are event driven. According to Hegel, philosophical history tries to synthesize historical data with philosophical conceptions and ideas, placing emphasis on thought over events. For Hegel, this form of history is most important because the course of human history is constantly directed by the principle of reason. Hegel insists that reason is embodied in nature.

Based on his idea of philosophical history, Hegel opined that the development of history is not a straight line or deterministic principle, but a movement that occurs through the conflict of opposites. In this case, a thesis gives birth to its response (antithesis), which disputes or refutes the thesis; the disputation causes a tension between the two which is eventually reconciled through a synthesis.

²⁰ G. HEGEL, *Lectures on the philosophy of world history*, [Reprint] ed.), (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1992) pp. 27–29

²¹ G. HEGEL, *Lectures on the philosophy of world history*, [Reprint] ed.), (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1992) pp. 27–29.

²² Stephen BELCHER, *Oral Traditions as Sources*, Online Pub., <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190277734.013.363>, accessed 30 May, 2024.

²³ Robert BROWN; Peter HODGSON (eds.), *Hegel: Lectures on the Philosophy of World History, Volume I: Manuscripts of the Introduction and the Lectures Of 1822-1823*, (Oxford University Press, 2019).

For Hegel, there are three essential moments in the development of history. These moments are inter-connected by an inherent contradiction where conflicts lead to synthesis. According to Hegel, the first moment is the moment of understanding whereby there seems to be an apparent stability or linear form of determination²⁴.

The second moment for Hegel is the negatively rational moment or the dialectical moment which is identified with instability²⁵. At this moment, the stability established at the first moment experiences an instability and shifts into its opposite. This is caused by a specific weakness, or something overlooked in the first moment. This process of accepting its opposite was termed *self-sublation* by Hegel. Self-sublation for Hegel has two meanings: to cancel as well as to preserve²⁶.

The third moment for Hegel is the speculative or positively rational moment. This is the unifying moment of the contradiction between the first two previous moments. It is the positive result of the dissolution or transition of those determinations²⁷. This third moment has in itself a content from which a new form emerges²⁸.

For Hegel, the dialectic movement from the first to the third moment is driven by necessity. The transition to another historical moment is necessitated by the lacuna in previous or earlier moments and hence grows out of the process itself. In other words, the presence of later determination or moments is a proof of weakness identified in the previous moments. Hegel also insists that since later determinations only “sublate” earlier determinations, the earlier determinations are not completely cancelled or negated. On the contrary, the essentials in the earlier historical moments are preserved within the later moments.

Theodor Mommsen (1817-1903): By the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, Khaldun’s historical method of historiography gained prominence among European scholars who focused more on a rational or positivist approach to history. One of such scholars was Theodor Mommsen. He was a German politician, philosopher and historian. In 1902, he won the Nobel prize in Literature for his historical masterpiece ‘The History of Rome’. History for Mommsen must be

²⁴ G. W. F. HEGEL, *Encyclopedia of the Philosophical Sciences in Basic Outline Part I: Science of Logic* [*Enzyklopädie der philosophischen Wissenschaften I*], Klaus BRINKMANN; Daniel O. DAHLSTROM (trans.), (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), p.80.

²⁵ G. W. F. HEGEL, *Encyclopedia of Logic*, p.81.

²⁶ G. W. F. HEGEL, *The Science of Logic* [Wissenschaft der Logik], translated by George di Giovanni (trans.), (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2010), p.107.

²⁷ G. W. F. HEGEL, *Encyclopedia of Logic*, p.82.

²⁸ G. W. F. HEGEL, *Phenomenology of Spirit*, A.V. MILLER (trans.), (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1977), p.79.

based on verifiable facts even if it was still written with the intention to instruct or show good example²⁹.

Karl Marx (1818-1883)

Marx was a German philosopher, political theorist and a socialist. His contributions to the Philosophy of History is based on his famous dialectical method, dialectical materialism. For Marx, all social institutions like culture, politics and even religion are by-products of the underlying economic system.

Karl Marx was influenced by Hegel's idea of dialectics in history and human society. Marx agrees with Hegel on the necessity of opposites for the realization of history, however, Marx views Hegel's position as idealistic and not realizable in concrete terms. For Marx, the dialectics should be based on solely materialistic determination since for Marx, all things are matter: the material world is perceptible to the senses and has an objective reality that is independent of the mind. Marx's theory tends towards dialectical materialism³⁰ or historical materialism. This materialist thought focused on natural and human based relations, insisting that there are essential paradoxes or functional contradictions that control these relations: for Marx, these contradictions are real, comparable to Kant's notion of "real oppositions" (*Realgegensätze*)³¹. Marx insists that when two forces oppose each other, such opposition or contradiction leads to a mutual development. Relating this to society, history is shaped through conflicts that arise between various social classes of the economic system³². In other words, all things develop through material contradictions.

Analysing the Hegelian dialectics, Marx recognized the Hegelian contradiction as the source of all dialectics³³. However, he insists that Hegel's position should be detached from its idealist foundation and reconstructed on historical-materialist ground. Of course, the view of Marx is based on the foundations of dialectical materialism. It should be mentioned that dialectical materialism's

²⁹ Jesse CARTER, *Theodor Mommsen*

<https://archive.org/details/atlantic93bostuoft/atlantic93bostuoft/page/372/mode/2up?view=theater>, (accessed 9th March 2025)

³⁰ P. THOMAS, *Marxism and Scientific Socialism: From Engels to Althusser*, London: Routledge, 2008.

³¹ Immanuel KANT, "An Attempt to Introduce the Concept of Negative Magnitudes into Philosophy," in Immanuel Kant, *Theoretical Philosophy*, 1755–1770, ed. and trans. David Walford, England: Cambridge University Press, 2003, pp. 203–241.

³² G. A. COHEN, *Karl Marx's Theory of History: A Defense*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2000.

³³ Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, vol. I, Ben FOWKES (trans.), New York: Knopf Doubleday, 1977, p. 744.

proponents believe that everything can be explained by nature because it is inherently materialistic³⁴.

According to historical materialism, contradictions are a constant process of development in nature. The motor of history is conflicts or contradictions. For instance, biological evolution occurs in animals and plants when their means of survival conflict with their surroundings. History evolves as incompatible parts confront each other, leading to either annihilation or adaptation³⁵.

When applied to human society, historical dialectics is responsible for the evolvement of civilizations. The basic needs in nature drives everybody to engage in economic activities leading to production. All things considered, this stipulation implies that every society is dependent upon its mode of production, it either adopts it or risks elimination. This explains why certain civilizations disappear and are replaced by others: as production methods change, they encounter new paradoxes that force them to be replaced by more sophisticated economic systems, which in turn give rise to new societies. In a specific sense, Marx insists that the contradictions in the capitalist system will ultimately result in the proletarian socialist revolution.

Friedrich Engels (1820-1895)

Frederich Engels was in consonance with the thoughts of his friend and colleague Karl Marx on the principle of dialectics. While Marx focused mainly on the economic systems of society, Engles applied his notion of dialectics to a broader spectrum of realities. Engels developed what he called ontological principles that could be said to inhere objectively in nature. Deriving from G. Hegel, Engels described nature and history under three broad dialectical “laws”: the transformation of quantity into quality and vice versa; the identity or unity of opposites; and the negation of the negation³⁶.

In the first instance, one can use biology to explain Engels’ proposition. According to the first law, a change in genetic expression might result in the production of something new (a qualitative change) when there is a quantitative rise in the population density of microorganisms. Growing bacterial populations cause the signals (chemicals) that each organism releases to build up to a point where they trigger genes, causing a mucilaginous biofilm phase to form in which the organisms embed themselves. Numerous species can form biofilms, which cling to nearly any surface—from teeth to soil roots to rocks in streams to water pipelines³⁷.

³⁴ The fundamental beliefs of dialectical materialism is that matter is in a state of perpetual change, that everything is material and descended from matter, and that all matter is interrelated and dependent on one another. Pascal CHARBONNAT, *Histoire des philosophies matérialistes*, Kimé, 2013.

³⁵ Jonathan SPERBER, *Karl Marx: A Nineteenth-Century Life*, New York : Liveright Publishing Corporation, 2013.

³⁶ Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Collected Works*, vol. 25 (New York: International Publishers, 1975, 356.

³⁷ Fred Magdoff and Chris Williams, *Creating an Ecological Society* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 2017), 215.

According to Bernal, Engel's second law on the identity or unity of opposites, according to Bernal, has two implications: everything implies its opposite; and there are no hard and fast lines in nature³⁸.

The negation of negation, the third and most significant of Engel's dialectical laws, deals with emergence. It was an attempt to ascribe history with ontological laws. This third principle suggests that anything in the objective world will eventually give rise to something different, a new emergent reality that represents new material relations and emergent levels. This will frequently happen because of the action of residual elements or recessive factors that have already been overcome but still exist today. A hierarchy of organizational levels might be inferred from material existence as a whole, although transformative change frequently involved moving from one organizational level to another, similar to the process of growing from a seed into a plant. Bhaskar argued that this third dialectical law "raises the issue of absencing absences and the reassertion of lost or negated elements of reality"³⁹. Bernal analyzed the dialectical law of negation in terms of the "role of residuals that reemerge and transform relations through complex evolutionary processes"⁴⁰.

The relationship between negation and historical emergence/evolution can be illustrated with the biological interaction between plants and parasitic insects. As insects consume plant leaves, plants have developed a variety of defense mechanisms. These include creating substances that prevent the insect from feeding and releasing substances that draw in creatures—typically tiny wasps—that deposit their eggs within the insect, killing it as the eggs hatch. This process continuously repeats itself, as creatures interact, evolution is always changing things, sometimes significantly. In some cases, this leads to fundamental changes in whole ecosystems and the rise of new dominant species in particular environments. As Engels wrote, emergence, in the sense of "the negation of the negation, really does take place in both [plant and animal] kingdoms of the natural world"⁴¹.

What Engels sought to achieve with his dialectics of history was to discover a synthesis to all the processes affecting life and reality, both human and non-human. This synthesis was primarily based on his conception of dialectical movement and change, emphasizing the complexity of material interactions and the introduction of new emergent powers, in a continuous process of origin, development and decline.

³⁸ J. D. Bernal, "Dialectical Materialism," in *Aspects of Dialectical Materialism*, by Hyman Levy et al. (London: Watts and Co., 1934), 107–8.

³⁹ Roy Bhaskar, *Dialectic: The Pulse of Freedom* (London: Verso, 1993), 150–52, 377–78

⁴⁰ Bernal, "Dialectical Materialism," 103–4.

⁴¹ Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Collected Works*, *ibid*, vol. 25, 126.

Marc Bloch (1866-1944).

Bloch was one of France's most significant historians throughout the first half of the 20th century. While lecturing at the University of Strasbourg, Bloch came in contact with another historian Lucien Febvre and together they founded the Annales School⁴². By 1929, this school began publishing the journal *Annales d'histoire économique et sociale*.

Bloch's aim in publishing the *Annales* was to counter the method of historical investigation that was in vogue during his time which paid less attention to the human agent but focused more on events. Bloch believed it was his responsibility to reverse such 'non-social' inclination and give history a sociological background⁴³.

In one of his masterpieces *The Historian's Craft* whose original French title was *Apologie pour l'histoire ou Métier d'historien*, Bloch developed a new and unique approach to historical enquiry. He wrote this work in 1944 while he was held in a camp as a prisoner of war, however it was posthumously published in 1949 and first published in English in 1953.

Actors beget Structures and Structures identify actors

In *The Historian's Craft*, Bloch defined what in his view constitutes history and how the historian should represent his findings. In this magnum opus which was inspired by the question "what is history?" posed by his son Étienne⁴⁴, Bloch gave a remarkable definition of history as 'man in time'⁴⁵.

According to this definition, humans are the main subjects of history. The historical line is simply the investigation of the interaction between the human agent and his environment. This interaction determines the structures or systems of the human society, for instance thought and belief system, the social, political, cultural and environmental systems. Therefore, human activity, innovation,

⁴² Katherine STIRLING, "Rereading Marc Bloch: The Life and Works of a Visionary Modernist", In *History Compass*, vol. 5, March 2005, pp. 525–538.

⁴³ Katherine STIRLING, "Rereading Marc Bloch: The Life and Works of a Visionary Modernist", *ibid.*

⁴⁴ M. HUGHES-WARRINGTON, *Fifty Key Thinkers on History*, 3rd ed. London: Routledge, 2015, 16.

⁴⁵ Katherine STIRLING, "Rereading Marc Bloch: The Life and Works of a Visionary Modernist", *ibid.*

conflict and interaction are the primary focus and materials of history⁴⁶. This interpretation of Bloch was a clear paradigm shift. Before Bloch, history was typically characterized by philosophers and historians as the study of eras, epochs, centuries, reigns and civilizations. For Bloch, these categories employed as the main objects of history deemphasizes the importance of the 'actor' and the 'context' of his actions. History for Bloch involves a reconstruction of the actions, values, beliefs and interactions that occupy the moments of 'man in time'. Although Bloch was writing in reference to the defeat of France during the war in 1940, his description of history relates to all times.

History within this context is "actor-centered", the actor or historical agent determines the course of events either through adaptation or innovation. For instance, humans produced thick cloaks to adapt to cold weather while the airplane was a human innovation to solve the problem of interactive distance. In other words, if there are historical structures and systems, they depend on the ideas, attitudes, and deeds of specific individuals. If there are historical reasons, they also depend on human actions and interactions in a human-made environment. In this view, the situation of Nigeria is a dependent effect of the actions and interactions of Nigerians within the context of their environment over the course of time.

One may say that Bloch's perspective on history centers on the historical players or actors in time. Simply said, history must recognize the importance of the human content in historical investigation. The historian is to pay attention to the link that exists between actors and systems. A historical event informs about the circumstances of the historical actors. The embedded corruption in the Nigerian system is a product of a stratification process that developed from the inception of the Nigerian State in 1960 till the present political dispensation.

A good historical knowledge of the Nigerian situation requires that the historian should take into account the thought and belief system, the social, political, cultural and environmental factors of the Nigerian people through the span of their existence as a nation. The work of the historian therefore is to investigate how people behaved as they went about living their lives in the context

⁴⁶ Katherine STIRLING, *ibid.*

of these enabling factors. For instance, a historical investigation on the relationship between law and discipline in Igbo land in the 18th century should involve an understanding of gerontocracy and kingship structures which were the political systems of the people at that time. Hence, societal structures or systems are dependent upon the mental frameworks, actions, and relationships of the individual actors who make up these systems. A lawful society was produced through the action and interaction of the human agents who decided to make the law an indispensable determinant of the social order. It was not the promulgation of laws that automatically determined the value of law in the society, rather it was the decision and interaction of the human agents towards the promulgation of laws that gave the law its active value. The promulgated laws of Nigeria are enough to make her reach any formidable height, but Nigerians' interaction towards the legal system is responsible for the lack of value or reference of law in the country. In other words, a lawless society does not mean the absence of law but the unwillingness of the citizens or human actors to recognize its presence and importance.

Therefore, an objective history looks at the social and physical settings in which people make decisions. The institutional and situational contexts in which events and actions occur must be taken into consideration in a historian's description of such events and behaviors. A solid awareness of the family systems, educational systems, religious convictions, cultural and moral norms should exist.

Reality is a historical continuity

Going further, Bloch also insisted that any objective historical investigation must take cognizance of the value of inclusivity and comparison. The present is unique but yet is a product of the past. According to Bloch, "*misunderstanding of the present is the inevitable consequence of ignorance of the past. But a man may wear himself out just as fruitlessly in seeking to understand the past, if he is totally ignorant of the present*"⁴⁷. To understand the present requires a good knowledge of the past.

⁴⁷ M. BLOCH, *The Historian's Craft: Reflections on the Nature and Uses of History and the Techniques and Methods of Those Who Write It*, trans. Peter Putnam, reprint, Manchester University Press, 1992, 43.

Michel Foucault (1926-1984)

Foucault was a French historian and philosopher.

In his work *Society must be defended*, Foucault made a revolutionary claim to the concept of truth. In his view, truth, this time historical truth is not absolute but the fragile product of a historical struggle or struggle between nations based on influence. As a result, reality is relative. Using this method, he developed a historical thesis that critiqued the French political history. Foucault demonstrates how the historical discourse differs from the legal and philosophical discourses in how it views truth, which is no longer absolute but rather the result of conflict.